# WrestleCraft roadmap: what to build first, what waits, what to cut

Oct 21, 2026 · @Bill

## The short version

Stop adding systems and make the live show the thing every other system feeds. The game has 102 engine files and more than 450 open, planned or wished-for items across nine lists. The killer features PDF names the core: you run the show live from the gorilla position, and people remember every call you make. Every item below was judged on one question: **does it make the live show, or the week that feeds into it, better and easier to feel?**

- **Build first (next 4 to 6 weeks):** clean up the lists and fix known bugs. Then make the show louder: a mid-card act catching fire on air, more kinds of call, decisions that feel big, commentary that remembers, word that travels through the locker room, and a Director that paces the fires.
- **Then give it a past and a first hour:** simulated pre-history, backstories, the last booker's desk as the tutorial, and the black book.
- **Ship it:** the Steam build has never talked to the Steam client, no Windows installer exists, and the gamepad has never been tried on hardware. These gate the launch more than any feature.
- **Wait until after launch:** the GM skill tree, owner mode, most of the creator suite, multiplayer, new modes and the tycoon ideas.
- **Cut:** fast mode leftovers, pre-booking the week, picking the building, fixed-length feuds and storyline templates, five goals for every show, the four-kinds-of-fan proposal, and anything left from the DOS, tablet and TV eras.

One risk sits above all of these. The art direction changed five times between 6 and 19 October (grey windows, paper Macintosh, scrapbook, workbench). Each change reopened "move every page to the new look". Lock the workbench look now, or the art queue will keep eating the feature queue.

## What was read

Everything below comes from the repo at version 0.88 (last merge 20 October) and the killer features PDF. The GitHub repo has no open issues and the code has no TODO or FIXME comments, so the lists are the whole backlog.

| Source | Open items | State |
|---|---|---|
| `TASKS.md` | 144 unticked boxes | Many are stale: sections 3 to 9 were finished another way through `NEXT.md`, and sections 0v, 0w and 0x appear twice |
| `docs/roadmap.md` (the next 30) | 16 (items 15 to 30) | Items 1 to 14 done. The current work queue |
| `docs/plans/week-of-20-october.md` | 8 steps | Living world work; mostly built (`99-reigns`, `99-midstory`, `99-worldweek`) |
| `WISHLIST.md` | 1 (wish 25, storyline templates) | 97 of 100 done |
| `docs/proposals/` | 3 (four kinds of fan, owner mode, trouble in public) | Decided in `TASKS.md`, not built |
| `docs/plans/` (characters, creator suite, storylines, gorilla position) | About 40 steps | Characters plan waits on decisions |
| `docs/ideas/a-plus-plus-plus-plus.md` | 200 ideas | A list to ponder, nothing promised |
| `IDEAS.md` | 100 ideas | Shelved on 3 October |
| Killer features PDF | 17 ideas | Research, 21 October |

Known bugs from `docs/decisions-needed.md` and the run notes are counted under Build first.

# Build first, in this order

The order goes from cheap to deep. Each step makes the live show louder before any new system is added. Sizes follow the repo's own scale: S is about a commit, M a few, L a planned project.

## Step 0: clear the ground (about a week)

| # | Item | Source | Size | Why now |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0.1 | One backlog. Untick nothing; mark the stale `TASKS.md` boxes done or cut, remove duplicate sections, retire `IDEAS.md` and `docs/next-round.md`, rewrite the stale parts of `docs/design.md` | All lists | S | The design doc still describes a DOS look, tablet and TV modes, and "the odds decide who wins". Every future run reads it |
| 0.2 | Lock the workbench look and freeze art direction changes | `CLAUDE.md` rule 2a | S | Five looks in two weeks reset the page-by-page queue each time |
| 0.3 | Fix Suggest a card when a parody brand runs thin | Run notes 0.83 | S | Weekly shows with two matches break the first impression |
| 0.4 | Fix the desk map when a city has no state outline | Decisions needed | S | The desk is the first screen of every week |
| 0.5 | Give WPW's belts their holders | Decisions needed | S | Vacant belts flood the first week with title changes |
| 0.6 | Stretch the stars (two stars is bad, four and a half is rare) | `TASKS.md` 0o.4 | M | Stars are the show's main payout; they need range |
| 0.7 | The giant fired on 2 of 3 seeds, two companies broke | Decisions needed | M | Balance check, not a feature |

## Step 1: make the show louder (3 to 4 weeks)

| # | Item | Source | Size | What it does for the core |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1.1 | **Catching fire, live.** A mid-card act outperforming gets a call: more time, a mic after, or stick to the sheet | PDF E2, design.md 2a | S to M | The quickest win. The design doc names it as missing |
| 1.2 | **More kinds of call:** a manager at ringside, a debut, a walk-out, a double turn, a referee who misses the finish, a rival's star in the building | `TASKS.md` 0e | M | More variety in the one screen that makes the game unique |
| 1.3 | **Every show leaves something.** Today one show in four leaves a matter. Add causes: a soft house, real heat, a promo off the script, a rival's offer, an unhappy sponsor | `TASKS.md` 0i | M | The one-more-turn rule, at the hand-off from Show to Office |
| 1.4 | **Decisions that feel big.** Concepts, then build the picked one for calls and matters | Roadmap 23 to 25 | M | Calls are the core moment; they should look like it |
| 1.5 | **The show tells one story.** Commentary that remembers last week, catchphrases, the crowd as a character, sponsor spots | Roadmap 26, 27, PDF P4 | M to L | Fold P4 (voices) in here; it is the same grammar work |
| 1.6 | **Word travels, and wrestlers remember each other.** How you treat one person moves their friends; memories between wrestlers | PDF R4, roadmap 29b | S then M | Every call ripples; small to build on `youRemember()` |

| # | Item | Source | Size | What it does for the core |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1.7 | **The hallway.** Three to five overheard lines a week, picked by what just happened | PDF R2 | M | Makes the relationship matrix audible without a new mechanic |
| 1.8 | **The Director.** Confirmed by Bill on 21 October. A weekly tension score (open matters, clocks, morale, cash, feud heat) picks which eligible events fire, with three personas the player chooses: the Promoter, the Carny, the Purist. Start with the score in tests only, then let it choose | PDF E1 | M | Gives "the office opens on a fire" a shape instead of flat chances. Absorbs `TASKS.md` 0h dynamic required actions |

## Step 2: a past, and a first hour (4 to 6 weeks)

| # | Item | Source | Size | Why |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2.1 | **Decide the default world** (original, parody, or both) | Characters plan, decisions 1 and 2 | Decision | Everything in this step depends on it, and so does the legal position at launch |
| 2.2 | **Simulated pre-history.** Run 10 to 25 years before day one | PDF P1 | L | Gives sifting, callbacks and "they have history" real material from week one. Check generation time and save size first |
| 2.3 | **Backstories from what happened**, plus the backstory block and traits | PDF P2, characters plan steps 1 to 3 | M | One job: the plan's generator is P2 |

| # | Item | Source | Size | Why |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2.4 | **The last booker's desk** as the opening, with the first-year required actions folded in (the authority figure before the third big event) | PDF V4, `TASKS.md` 0h | M | Replaces a tutorial with a mystery. The first hour is where 100 systems bury the core |
| 2.5 | **The black book.** Secrets and favours you can hold and spend, both ways. Trouble in public (decided: build it, gritty) feeds it secrets | PDF R1, proposal, `TASKS.md` decisions | M | Turns the kayfabe layer and promises into play |
| 2.6 | **Rivals react to you.** Rival companies raid your stars and answer your moves, with one rival booker who knows you | Roadmap 29, PDF R5 | M | A face for the world; rivals already keep feuds since 20 October |
| 2.7 | **Arcs on the Net and in History**, then the invasion and plain-build arcs | Roadmap 17, 15, 16 | S, then M | 17 is cheap and makes arcs part of the record |

## Ship it: release blockers

The recorded decision is a full Steam release, not early access. None of these are features, but each one can stop a launch, and none has been run yet. Start them alongside step 1, because they need hardware and accounts more than code.

| Blocker | State today | Source |
|---|---|---|
| Steam calls (achievements, Workshop upload) | Written, never run against the Steam client | `TASKS.md` 12, commercial roadmap |
| Windows installer and icon | Not built; needs a Windows host | Commercial roadmap |

| Blocker | State today | Source |
|---|---|---|
| Gamepad and Steam Deck on real hardware | Simulated keys only | `TASKS.md` 12, 0 |
| Diorama renderer at 60 fps on a Steam Deck, with a quality setting | Rule 0 target, not measured | `CLAUDE.md` rule 0 |
| Workshop: wrestlers and whole worlds only, with a file check and a report button | Planned for every creator; ship two kinds first | `TASKS.md` 0v |
| Licence and the parody world's legal footing | No licence chosen; parody notes still in git history | Decisions needed |
| Save size over a long career | Fine to about week 150; recheck after pre-history (2.2) | `NEXT.md` 12.6 |

## Build with the art

These show the game the player already has. Build each one only when the piece of art it rides on is ready, not before.

| Item | Source | Rides on |
|---|---|---|
| The corkboard: the locker room as photos and red string | PDF R3 | Wrestlers remember each other (1.6), cliques |
| The office that remembers: objects from great nights on the desk | PDF V1, idea 46 | The desk in the workbench look |
| The year in paper: a shareable zine of the year. Merge in the poster maker (idea 101) and the season card (idea 162) | PDF E4 | Create a Scene templates (poster, magazine cover already exist) |
| More stills: the trainer's room, the parking lot, the owner, a contract, a mutiny | `TASKS.md` 0w | Create a Scene |

| Item | Source | Rides on |
|---|---|---|
| Scenes for invasions and arc chapters | `TASKS.md` 0u | Arcs (2.7) |
| Buildings that remember: crowd signs, banners, heat for a return to the scene | PDF V3 | The road and venues |
| The build-a-match screen and the show on the air redone in the paper look | `TASKS.md` 0u | Locked art direction (0.2) |

The locker room as a place (PDF V2) also belongs here, but it is the biggest of these. Do it last.

## Wait until after launch

These are good ideas, but each one adds a layer beside the live show rather than feeding it. Build them on a game that has already shipped.

| Item | Source | Why it waits |
|---|---|---|
| The GM skill tree, points, level notifications, legacy score | Roadmap 18 to 22 | Five branches is a lot of new numbers. If it comes back, make perks change the calls on the air (an extra answer, a better read) so it feeds the core. The legacy score is the cheap part worth keeping |
| Owner mode | Proposal; decided "after release" | Already decided. It also takes you away from the gorilla position, so it needs a rethink |
| Creator suite expansion: Create an Arena, a Prop, a Show, a Poster, thrown props, the animation timeline, Blender parts with sockets | `TASKS.md` 0v, creator suite roadmap | The creators built so far are enough for launch. Each new one is a product of its own |

| Item | Source | Why it waits |
|---|---|---|
| Blender renders of the interface pieces | `TASKS.md` 0x, 0v3 | Polish once the look is locked |
| Arcs built from beats | PDF E3 | Rewards everything above being in place; port the three arcs first |
| They come back changed | PDF P3 | Strong idea, but get legal advice on the Nemesis patent first |
| Careers: fired, a job elsewhere, your own company after ten years | Roadmap 30 | Long-game content; most players will not reach it before launch reviews |
| Contracts by appearance, 6 months to 3 years | Roadmap 28 | Clauses and talks already give contracts depth |
| Pre-show extras: sponsor segments, a closing angle after the main event, shows of other lengths | `TASKS.md` 0g | Small, but none fixes a problem players have today |
| More reads to learn (style clashes, who draws where, hidden traits) | `TASKS.md` 0g | Good depth for fog of war, after launch |
| Tycoon ideas: build an arena, own a studio, buy a rival, shares, concessions | Ideas 21 to 40, `TASKS.md` 10 | A second game beside the booking game |
| Multiplayer (ideas 61 to 80) and new modes (81 to 100) | 200 ideas | The deterministic engine makes asynchronous play possible later; nothing about it is needed now |

## No longer makes sense

These are still open in a list somewhere, but a later decision or a built system has overtaken them. Close them so no future run builds them by mistake.

| Item | Where it is still open | Why it no longer fits |
|---|---|---|
| Fast mode, and the Assistant panel on Career | `TASKS.md` 3 and the decisions table; 0g open question | Decided 16 October: no fast mode. A show on the air cannot be skipped, and that rule is the core. Remove the panel |
| Pre-book the week ( `S.cards` ) | `NEXT.md` 5.7, `TASKS.md` 3 | Each show now changes the next (feed, calls, matters). A card booked before Monday's show is stale by Friday. Draft cards for a big night (idea 187) cover the real need |
| Pick the city and the building before a show | `TASKS.md` 4, design.md 2d | Decided 16 October: the road picks the building. Markets and sell-out streaks are built |
| Short, medium and long feuds; rivalries as a separate system ( `S.rv` ) | `TASKS.md` 0q steps 4 to 7, storylines plan | Living storylines replaced fixed lengths. Rivalry history is better carried by sifting and wrestlers remembering each other (1.6) than by a second system |
| Storyline templates with fixed beats | Wish 25, `TASKS.md` 2 | Overtaken by living storylines and company arcs. If templates come back, it is as arcs built from beats (PDF E3) |
| Five goals for every show | `TASKS.md` 0g step 5 | A checklist on every show competes with reading the crowd and the story. The owner, the network and promises already set targets; the Director (1.8) can raise one when it matters |

| Item | Where it is still open | Why it no longer fits |
|---|---|---|
| Creative energy | `TASKS.md` 3 | Left out 16 October: freshness already does this |
| Four kinds of fan | Proposal | Audience share with six groups was built ( `src/99-audience.js` ). Close the proposal |
| Every page moved to the paper look, the scrapbook look, the grey windows | `TASKS.md` 0p, 0v2, 0w, 0x | Overtaken by the workbench look. Keep one "move pages to the workbench look" task |
| DOS look, CRT filter, scan lines, tablet and TV modes, 860px breakpoint | `docs/design.md` 5 and 6 | Rules 0, 2a and 5 replaced them |
| Terminal mode, theme packs, a companion phone app | Ideas 90, 179, 164 | Each works against the hand-made look or the wide-screen rule |
| A second big event in a month | Run notes | Decided: one big event a month, always |
| The startup's TV-deal pressure moved onto networks | `TASKS.md` 5 | Decided 16 October: it stays on the broadcast slot |
| `IDEAS.md` (the next 100) | Repo root | Shelved 3 October. Archive it so it stops being read |

## Decisions for Bill

These need an answer before step 2 starts. Nothing in this plan changes code; it is a reading of the lists.

- [ ] Lock the workbench look as final until launch?
- [ ] Default world at launch: an original world, the parody world, or both (characters plan, decisions 1 and 2)?

- [ ] Cut the items in "No longer makes sense" from `TASKS.md` and the plans, and archive `IDEAS.md`?
- [ ] Shrink the GM skill tree to perks that change the calls on the air, or drop it until after launch?
- [ ] Trouble in public was decided as gritty. Build it as a source of secrets for the black book rather than as its own event chain?

Worth noting: rule 9a says one step at a time with a go-ahead between steps. With this many steps, a weekly batch of three to five approved items would move faster without losing control.